

CORE FORMULA

Listen for overlap, name it specifically, avoid overclaiming, then invite the next practical step. -> It sounds like we both care about getting this handled cleanly. -> Different reasons, same concern about timing. -> We may not agree on the cause, but we both want a cleaner next step. -> The common thread is that nobody wants surprises here.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

It sounds like we both care about getting this handled cleanly.

BEST FOR

- When trust is low but there is a shared goal
- When a conversation is stuck in difference and needs one honest overlap
- When you need alignment without pretending full agreement
- When friction or overtalking is pulling the conversation off the thread that matters
- When you want to lower the temperature without conceding your own position

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short one-liners

- "It sounds like we both want this to go well."
- "Same goal, different angle."
- "We both want this handled cleanly."
- "I think we're after the same thing here."
- "Different reasons, same concern."
- "We both care about getting this right."
- "Sounds like we agree on the destination."

Warmth and connection · Rapport phrases

- "It sounds like we both care about getting this handled cleanly."
- "We may be coming from different angles, but I think we both want this to be clear."
- "The shared point seems to be protecting the relationship and the work."
- "We both seem to care about not making this worse."
- "It matters to both of us that this lands well."
- "I think we both want the same person to come out of this okay."
- "We're both trying to look after the same thing here."

Work and decisions · Meeting / decision phrases

- "It sounds like we're aligned on the timeline, even if the budget still needs a look."
- "The shared goal seems to be making the next step workable."
- "Different reasons, same concern about timing."
- "We both want a decision we can actually stand behind."
- "The common thread is that nobody wants surprises here."
- "We both want this to hold up when it's reviewed."
- "Whatever we decide, we both want something the team can run with."

Naming the overlap · Clear, direct phrases

- "The overlap I hear is that neither of us wants this to get messier."
- "We don't need full agreement to share the goal of a fairer process."

- "We may not agree on the cause, but we both want a cleaner next step."
- "Can we build from the part we do agree on?"
- "The useful part might be this: we both want a workable next step."
- "Where we line up is the timing — can we work from that?"
- "If we both want it to be fair, let's start there."

Softening and repair · De-escalation phrases

- "I don't want to pretend we see it the same way, but there is overlap in wanting a fair process."
- "We're on the same side of at least one thing here."
- "Neither of us wants this to blow up — can we start there?"
- "I know we disagree on the how; I think we agree on the why."
- "Let's not lose the thing we both actually want."
- "Before we get into where we differ, we both want this sorted."

Digital / text · Written, one line

- "I may be reading this wrong, but that seems like the key thread."
- "We can stay with that or move on — your call."
- "The useful part may be this: we both want the same outcome."
- "Sounds like we both want the same result, even if the route's different."
- "Feels like we agree on the goal — want to sort the how?"

Conflict and pressure · Low-trust phrases

- "I'm not asking you to drop your position — I think we still share one concern."
- "Even here, we both want this to be fair."
- "The last thing either of us wants is for this to get worse."
- "We can hold our differences and still work the part we share."
- "We may not agree on the cause, but we both want it sorted properly."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: We're exactly the same.
Better: We both care about this.
Best: We may not agree on the cause, but we both want a cleaner next step.
- Weak: You know what I mean.
Better: There's some overlap.
Best: The overlap I hear is that neither of us wants this to get messier.
- Weak: Let's just agree.
Better: We share one concern.
Best: We don't need full agreement to share the goal of a fairer process.

DECISION TREE

If They add detail

Follow the same thread; build on the overlap they just extended.
"Say more about that part."

If They look uncomfortable or tense

Release the move and reduce intensity.
"We don't have to stay with that."

If They ask for advice

Switch to Permission-based advice rather than pressing the overlap.
"Want my take, or just a sounding board?"

If They give a direct answer

Take it and move on — don't keep hunting for overlap.

If The situation needs action

Act directly rather than decorating the conversation with rapport.

If When unsure

One small move, then observe.

"It sounds like we both care about getting this handled cleanly."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Use the minimum viable move and keep the tone light. — "It sounds like we both want this to go smoothly."

Workplace conversation

Keep the wording concise and non-performative; avoid emotional overreach. — "The shared goal seems to be making the next step workable."

Conflict or repair

Pair the move with validation or autonomy release before naming the overlap. — "We may not agree on the cause, but neither of us wants this to get messier."

Digital message

Use one sentence only. Don't stack multiple prompts. — "I may be reading this wrong, but that seems like the key thread."

High-stakes context

Lead with direct clarity; add common ground only if it lowers pressure and improves understanding. — "Even here, we both want this to be fair."

Low-trust negotiation

Name one honest overlap early so you're clearly not there only to win. — "Different reasons, same concern about timing."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When common ground would minimise a real power difference or harm
- When the person needs their difference acknowledged before any overlap
- When the overlap would be fake, exaggerated, or self-serving
- When the situation needs direct action rather than more conversation
- When you would only be using the overlap to push toward your own outcome

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the overlaps

Think back over three recent conversations and write down the one honest thing you and the other person both wanted, even where you disagreed.

Day 2 — Write realistic lines

Write five real situations where naming common ground would help, and draft one overlap sentence for each.

Day 3 — Weak, better, best

For each of the five, write a weak version, a better version, and a best version that is short and tentative.

Day 4 — Cut by a third

Reduce each best version by about 30 percent so it sounds like attention, not a speech.

Day 5 — Add a recovery line

Pair each line with a recovery phrase you could use if the overlap doesn't land, such as "I may be reading that wrong."

Day 6 — Say it plainly

Say each line aloud in an ordinary tone until it stops sounding like a technique and starts sounding like you.

Day 7 — Use it once, then stop

In a real, low-stakes conversation, name one honest overlap, let it sit, and watch the response before doing anything else.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I keep the other person's autonomy intact?
- Did I use one move, or stack several?

- Did my tone fit the relationship and the context?
- Did I stop when the signal weakened?
- Did I follow their thread rather than my own agenda?
- Would a simpler response have been better?